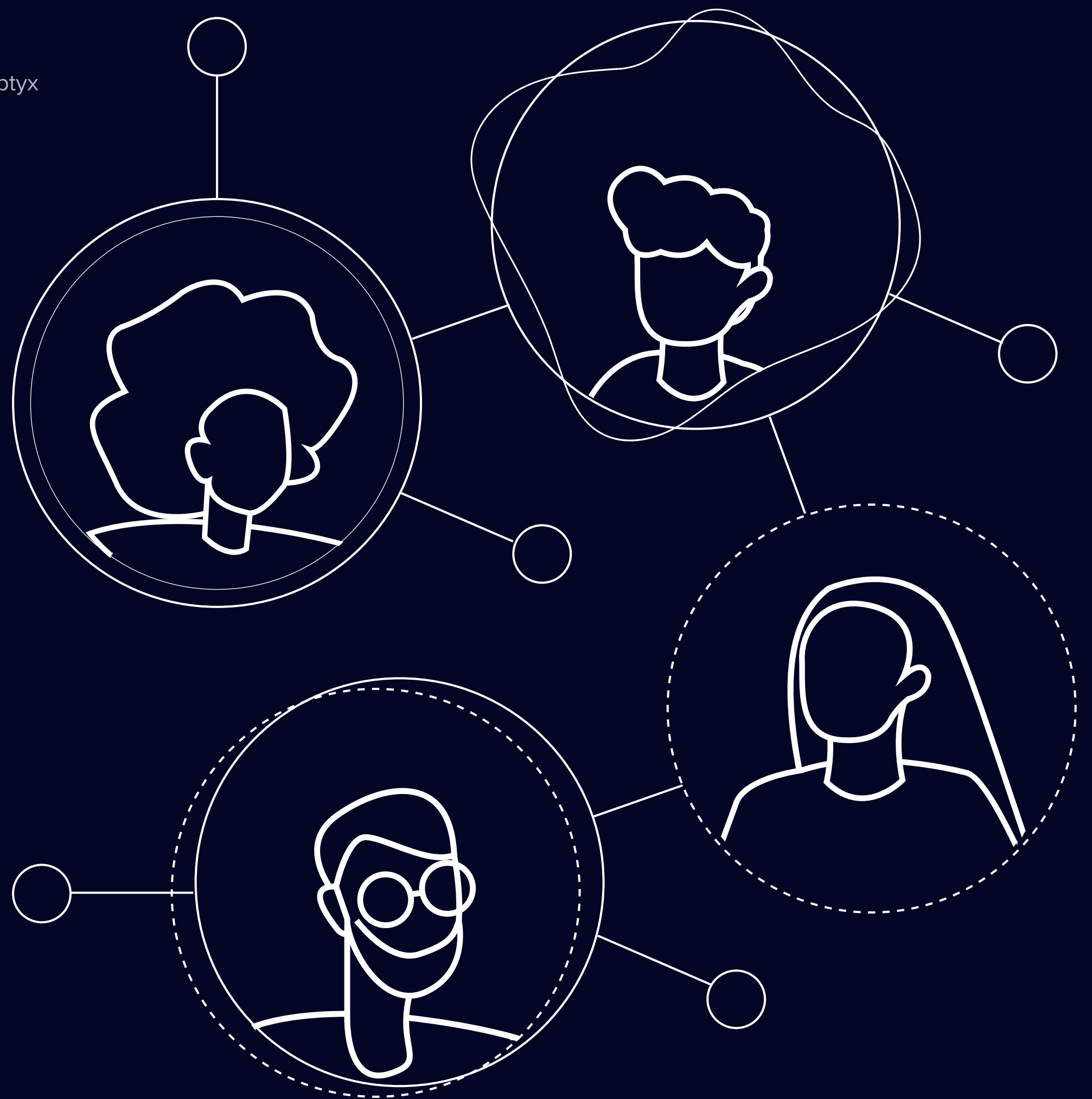


FIFTH ANNUAL

The State of Employee Listening 2026

Bradley Wilson, Ph.D.

Global Head of Workforce Insights & Innovation, Perceptyx



INTRODUCTION

Listening Under Pressure

The employee experience continues to operate under competing pressures. Organizations face mounting expectations for productivity and financial performance at the same time that HR functions absorb budget cuts and workforce reductions within their own teams. Employee listening programs remain widespread, but the capacity to act on what they capture is increasingly strained.

Now in its fifth year, Perceptyx's annual State of Employee Listening study tracks the listening and action practices that distinguish the highest-performing organizations from the rest. This edition includes data from more than 750 senior HR leaders at global organizations with 1,000+ employees, and for the first time introduces two new analytical lenses: organizational scale (from Startup through Integrated Enterprise) and organizational culture, using the Competing Values Framework (Relational, Innovative, Market, and Hierarchical).

Organizations that connect listening to business strategy, act on feedback at every level, and invest in the analytics capacity to target the right actions continue to outperform their peers on engagement, retention, innovation, and financial outcomes. But the path from data to impact is narrowing. Budget pressure, HR staff workload, and execution gaps are forcing even mature programs backward.

This report documents those shifts, quantifies their impact, and identifies the practices that allow organizations to sustain progress when resources tighten. Listening maturity alone does not produce outcomes. The organizations that outperform do three things together — they listen through multiple channels, they act on what they hear at every level of the organization, and they integrate listening data into personalized coaching and development. Prior Perceptyx research has established that this convergence of listening, action-taking, and learning & development (L&D) is what separates organizations that collect data from those that change behavior. The 2026 data reinforce that finding.

KEY FINDINGS AT A GLANCE

11x

Stage 4 organizations are more likely to achieve high levels of workforce engagement and retention

37%

of HR leaders now cite employee performance and productivity as the top talent priority, up from 23% in 2024

26%

rank budget as the #2 barrier to listening program success — a 65% increase from 2025

31%

of Stage 4 organizations identify the data-to-action gap as their top barrier

CONTEXT

The State of the Labor Market in 2025

4.6% U.S. unemployment rate by November 2025	7.1M Job openings by late 2025 (down from 2022 peak)	2.0% Quit rate — well below the 3.0% 'Great Resignation' highs	1.7M Layoffs and discharges per month nationally
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The labor market in 2025 presented a mixed picture that shaped the conditions under which HR leaders designed and executed their listening strategies. The U.S. unemployment rate rose to 4.6% by November 2025, up from 4.2% the prior November, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

Job openings continued a steady decline from their 2022 peak, falling to approximately 7.1 million by late 2025. The quit rate stabilized near 2.0%, well below the 3.0% highs of the "Great Resignation" era, signaling that voluntary turnover had cooled and workers were staying put — though not necessarily because they were satisfied.

Layoffs and discharges held relatively steady at about 1.7 million per month nationally, while payroll employment growth slowed. In February 2026, nonfarm payrolls declined by 92,000 and the unemployment rate edged to 4.4%.

These labor market conditions created a specific set of pressures for HR leaders: organizations pushed for higher productivity per employee while simultaneously tightening HR budgets — explaining the rise of performance and productivity as the top talent priority, and the emergence of budget constraints as the second-largest barrier to listening program success.

RESEARCH FOCUS

Listening Under Constraint

The 2026 study asks how HR leaders allocate listening attention when performance pressure rises and resources tighten. Previous editions tracked the progression of listening and action maturity across a four-stage model based on 13 differentiating practices identified from more than 65 common listening practices examined since 2022. That model remains the backbone of this report. However, two new dimensions help explain the patterns we observe.

Organizational Scale
For the first time, we categorize organizations across five stages of scale — Startup, Growth, Established, Expanding, and Integrated Enterprise — to examine how the constraints that accompany growth shape which outcomes leaders prioritize and how they design their listening programs.

Organizational Culture
We also assess organizational culture using the Competing Values Framework, classifying organizations as primarily Relational, Innovative, Market/Competitive, or Hierarchical. This lens reveals which cultural conditions enable or inhibit listening maturity.

THE 2026 CONSTRAINT: CAPACITY
27%
HR Workload
cite workload as a top barrier to program success

26%
Budget
cite budget as a top barrier — a 65% increase from 2025

What Business and Talent Outcomes Do Organizations Prioritize in 2026?

Before examining the mechanics of listening maturity, we must understand what leaders are trying to solve with their programs. In 2026, the answer is productivity.

Employee performance and productivity now tops the list of talent priorities at 37% — a 14-point increase from 2024 (23%). Continuous improvement and innovation follows a similar trajectory, climbing from 7% in 2024 to 25% in 2026. Together, these two priorities signal that organizations are using their listening programs to fuel output-oriented goals.

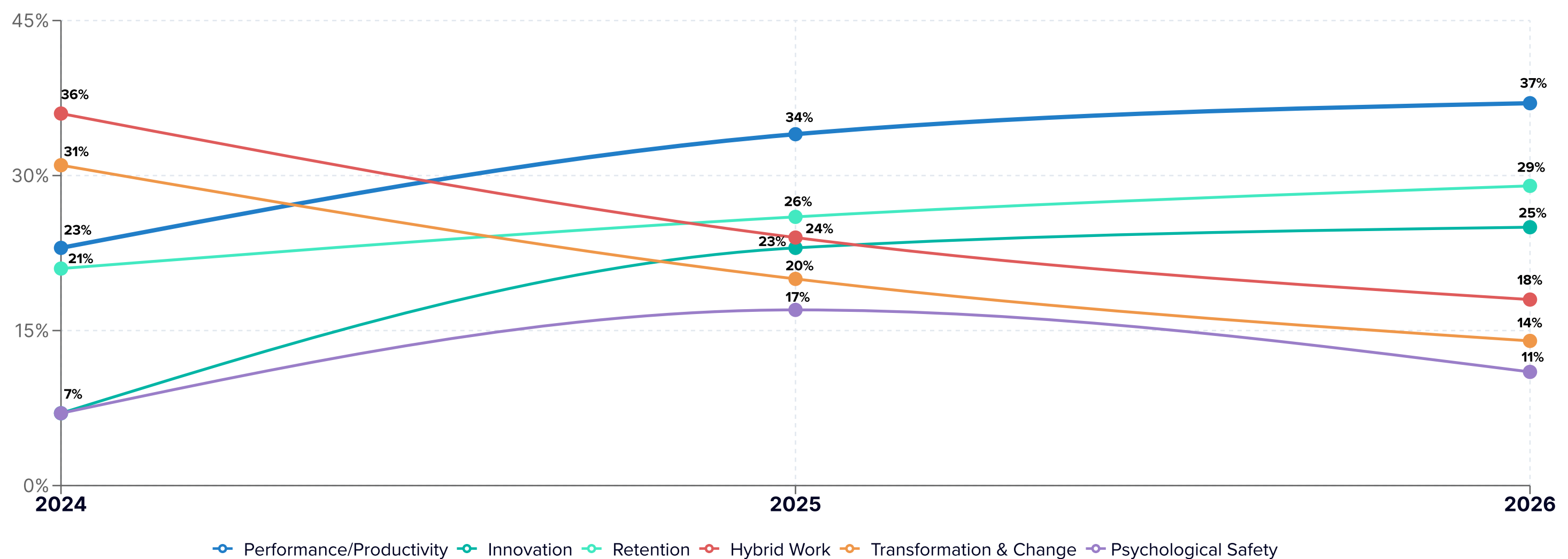
Employee retention rose to 29%, but the character of that priority has shifted. HR leaders describe a move from broad retention efforts toward targeted retention of critical talent and high performers. Health and wellbeing remained stable at 29%.

Several priorities that spiked in prior years have declined. Hybrid work experience — a top-five priority in both 2024 (36%) and 2025 (24%) — dropped to 18%. Psychological safety fell from a 2025 peak of 17% to 11%. Sustainability and safety culture similarly pulled back, suggesting organizations are consolidating focus around performance-linked outcomes.

37%

of organizations now prioritize Employee Performance/Productivity — up from 23% in 2024

Top Talent Priority Trends (2024–2026)



Talent Priorities Trend (2024–2026)

PRIORITY	2024	2025	2026	CHANGE (2025→2026)
Employee Performance/Productivity	23%	34%	37%	▲ +3
Employee Retention	21%	26%	29%	▲ +3
Employee Health & Well-Being	17%	29%	29%	0
Continuous Improvement/Innovation	7%	23%	25%	▲ +2
Employee Engagement/eNPS	9%	22%	21%	▼ -1
Manager Effectiveness	18%	21%	20%	▼ -1
Hybrid Work Experience	36%	24%	18%	▼ -6
Career Progression/Career Pathways	22%	21%	18%	▼ -3
Diversity, Equity, Inclusion & Belonging	11%	20%	18%	▼ -2
Customer/Patient Satisfaction	6%	21%	18%	▼ -3
Profitability/Efficiency	29%	19%	17%	▼ -2
Sustainability	3%	22%	16%	▼ -6
Safety Culture	6%	19%	15%	▼ -4
Transformation & Change	31%	20%	14%	▼ -6
Psychological Safety	7%	17%	11%	▼ -6
Merger & Acquisition Change Mgmt	3%	16%	10%	▼ -6

“
"Organizations are telling us: we want to support productivity and innovation, and we want to retain critical talent — but as a means to the end of performance."
”

What Barriers Block Employee Listening Program Success?

HR staff workload continues to rank as the top barrier to listening program success at 27% — consistent with the 30% reported in 2025 but a massive escalation from 2024, when only 6% cited it. The pressure on HR functions that emerged during 2025's restructuring wave has not eased.

The biggest shift in 2026 is budget, which jumped to 26% and now sits as the second-largest barrier. This represents a **65% increase from 2025 (16%)** and reflects broader organizational cost scrutiny. HR leaders report increased pressure to demonstrate measurable returns from listening program spending.

Action planning and follow-through remains a persistent challenge at 22%, unchanged from 2025 but substantially lower than the 41% reported in 2024. Manager talent and skills tied at 22%, and change management capabilities held at 19%.

Two barriers that were highly ranked in prior years have declined sharply: alignment with business outcomes dropped from 24% to 16%, and internal people analytics capabilities fell from 27% to 11%. Organizations feel better aligned strategically but lack the operational capacity — staff time, budget, and managerial skill — to execute on what their data tells them.

65%

increase in HR leaders citing budget as a barrier to listening program success (2025 to 2026)

Top Barriers to Employee Listening Program Success (2024–2026)

BARRIER	2024	2025	2026	CHANGE (2025→2026)
HR Staff Workload	6%	30%	27%	▼ -3
Budget BIGGEST JUMP	20%	16%	26%	▲ +10
Action Planning / Follow-Up Actions	41%	22%	22%	—
Manager Talent & Skills	31%	24%	22%	▼ -2
Change Management Capabilities	19%	19%	19%	—
Executive Support	36%	21%	18%	▼ -3
Technical Integration	9%	19%	18%	▼ -1
Alignment with Business Outcomes	8%	24%	16%	▼ -8
Program Adoption	11%	19%	15%	▼ -4
Program Design / Knowing What's Next	27%	20%	14%	▼ -6
Manager Buy-in	10%	17%	14%	▼ -3
Internal People Analytics Capabilities	27%	27%	11%	▼ -16
Relationship with External Vendor	5%	20%	11%	▼ -9

How Fast Are Organizations Turning Survey Data into Manager-Ready Results?

Effective listening programs get results to managers fast. In 2026, nearly a third of organizations (32%) deliver results within one to two weeks — the most common timeframe. An additional 29% deliver within three to four weeks, meaning 77% of organizations provide results within a month of survey close.

The share of organizations achieving sub-one-week turnaround softened to 16%, down from a 2025 high of 20%. This dip likely reflects the resource and budgetary constraints HR leaders currently face. The longer tail has improved somewhat: 7% still take more than eight weeks, down from 9% in 2022 but up from 3% in 2025.

Perceptyx research has established that perceived inaction following a survey is associated with decreased credibility and trust in senior leadership. When employees report they did not see change at the local level after a listening event, they are 2.5 times as likely to disagree or strongly disagree that senior leaders' actions align with organizational values. Delayed results erode trust in leadership, regardless of how good the data is.

77%

deliver results within one month of survey close

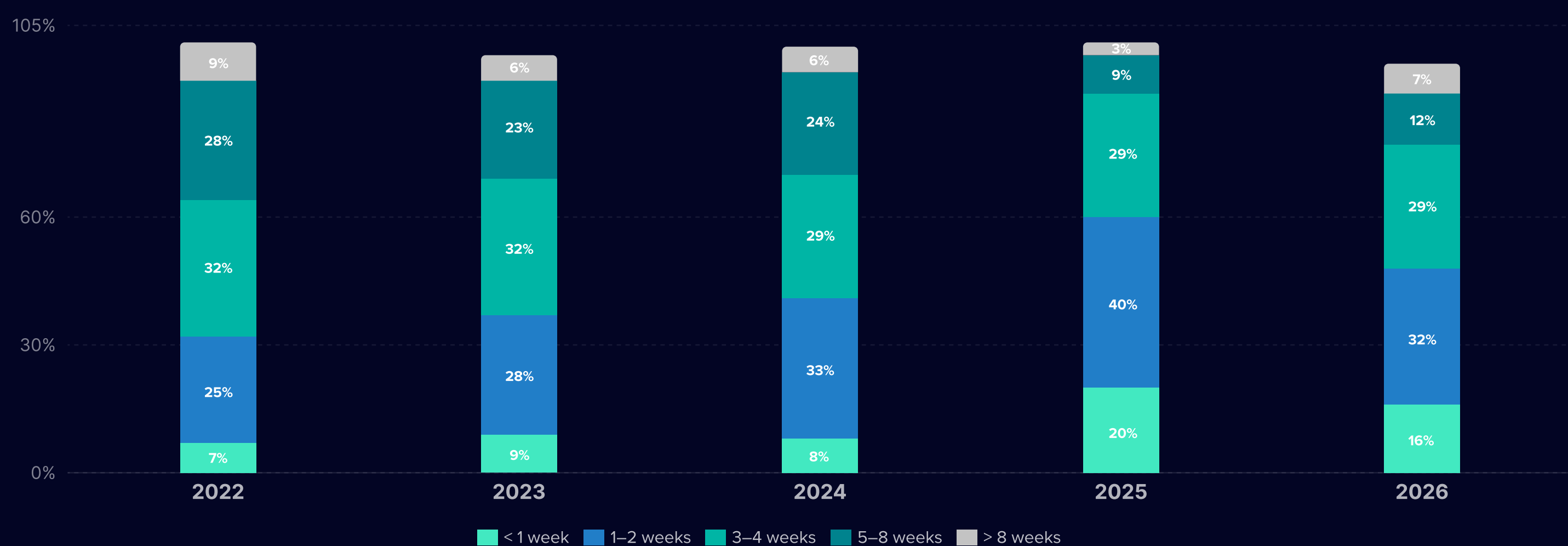
32%

deliver within 1–2 weeks — the most common timeframe

16%

achieve sub-one-week turnaround in 2026 (down from 20%)

Time to Data Trend (2022–2026)



2.5×

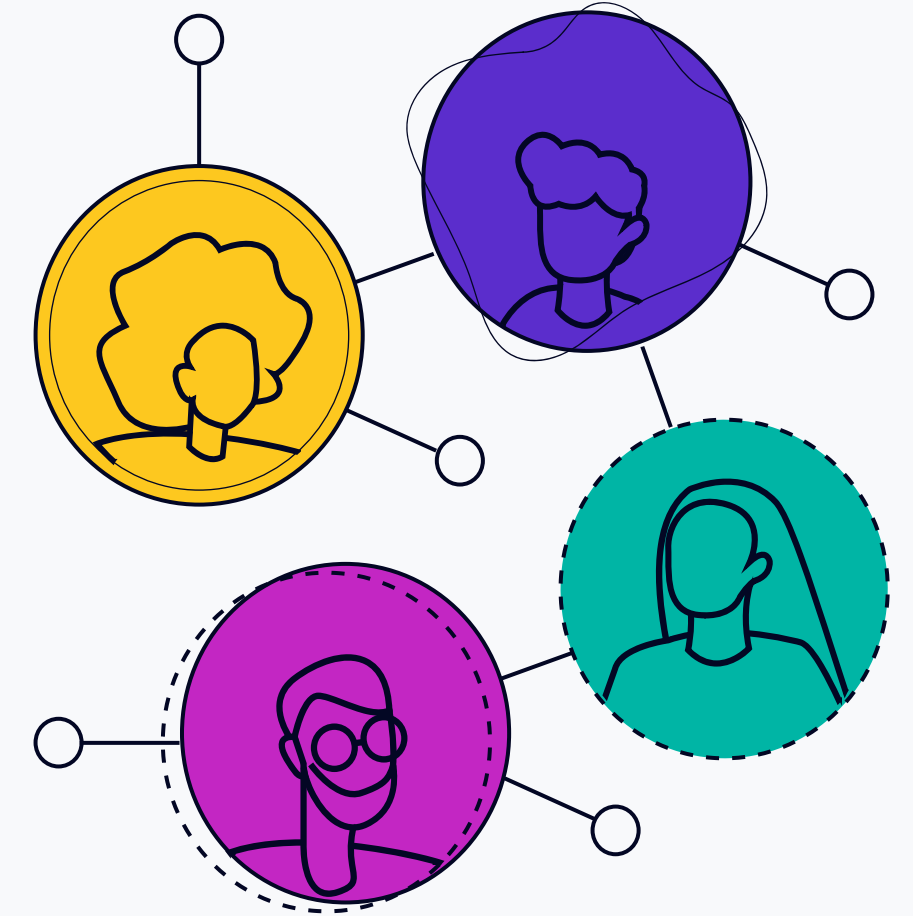
When employees do not see change after a listening event, they are 2.5× as likely to question whether senior leaders' actions align with organizational values.

PERCEPTYX RESEARCH

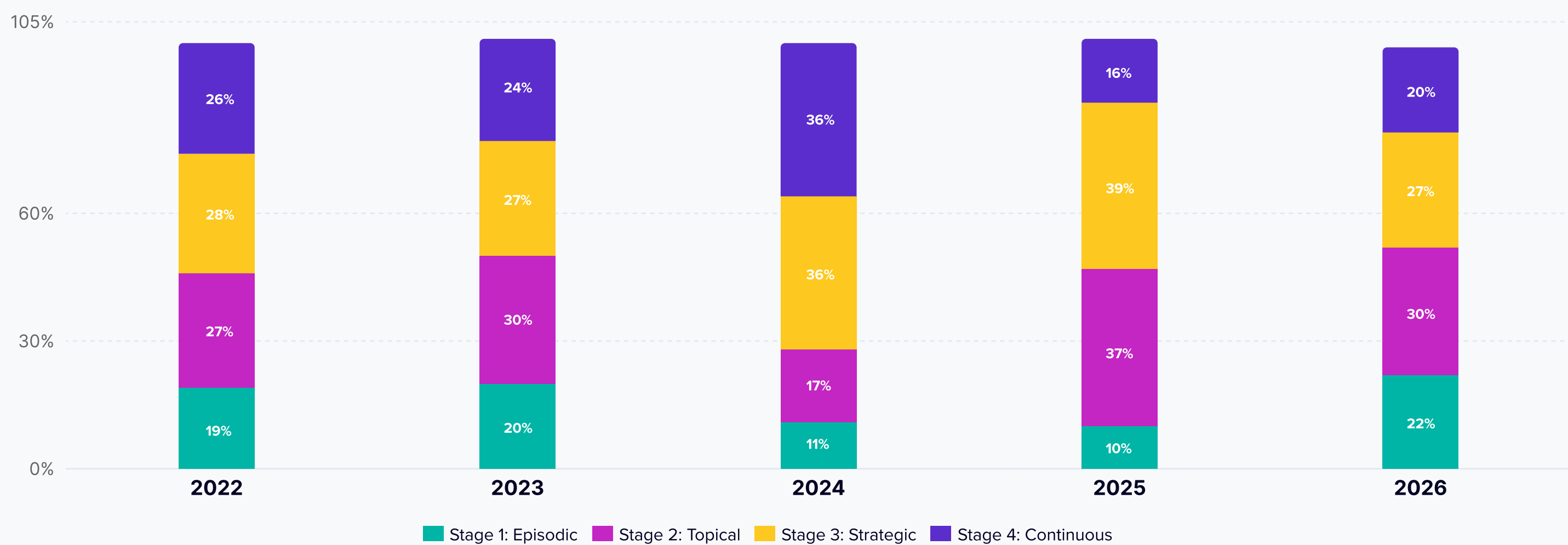
What Does Listening Maturity Look Like in 2026?

The 2026 maturity distribution regressed. Stage 1 (Episodic) organizations — those with traditional, siloed, HR-centered listening programs — rose to 22% of the sample, the highest share since the study began in 2022. Stage 2 (Topical) dropped to 30% following a 2025 spike to 37%, which likely reflected a wave of event-driven listening tied to organizational change initiatives. Stage 3 (Strategic) contracted sharply from 2025, and Stage 4 (Continuous) rebounded modestly but remained below 2024 levels.

This regression is consistent with the resource constraints documented earlier. In a budget-constrained environment where HR workload is strained, organizations are simplifying their listening programs, slowing their action cadence, and reverting to episodic approaches. The emphasis on performance and productivity should encourage more mature listening (which is positively associated with both outcomes), but the resource cuts that accompany that emphasis undermine the programs designed to deliver it.



Maturity Level Trend (2022–2026)



22%

of organizations are at Stage 1 in 2026 — the highest share since this study began

The Four Stages of Organizational Listening and Action Maturity

Perceptyx's first comprehensive study of large organizations, conducted in 2022, examined more than 65 common practices in employee listening. Of those, 13 emerged as key differentiators in achieving more favorable people and business outcomes, and organizations were categorized along a four-stage maturity model. Perceptyx has used this model in every subsequent edition of this study. The stages describe the quality of the listening and action program and the steps needed to move an organization from episodic listening to a continuous strategy that activates all employees in creating positive change.

750+ Organizations	13 Differentiating Practices	4 Stages of Listening and Action Maturity
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STAGE 1

Episodic Listening and Action

11%10%22%

202420252026

Organizations at this stage tend to have a traditional and straightforward listening strategy, often focused on a single survey event or a few isolated survey events on a tightly planned schedule. Their action strategy tends to be centered in Human Resources, with most follow-up to employee feedback seen as a function of HR. Listening events such as exit surveys, employee experience surveys, or developmental 360s are centered in different, discrete areas, often without connection. Their listening strategy tends to be consistent year after year, with few changes, and employee listening results are typically isolated from the larger business strategy. These organizations tend to act in a top-down manner, with planned, contained distribution of results and actions.



STAGE 2

Topical Listening and Action

17%37%30%

202420252026

Organizations at Stage 2 have seen the benefit of applying employee feedback to large-scale listening events as well as deep-dive topical events (M&A, IPO, senior leadership changes), projects geared toward specific goals (DEIB), or broadscale moments in the employee lifecycle such as exit surveys or 360 feedback. These listening projects are still discrete and centered in HR, but other departments now reach out for assistance. While each project likely has a broader business priority attached, closing the loop to demonstrate impact is often unsuccessful. Actions taken in response to employee feedback are still top-down, and the focus tends to be on compliance (did a manager submit an action plan?) instead of outcomes (did the employee experience improve?).



STAGE 3

Strategic Listening and Action

36% **39%** **27%**
2024 2025 2026

Stage 3 organizations have established a clear connection between their listening strategy and business priorities. They address business problems using multiple methodologies and listening channels outside traditional surveys. Less importance is placed on a single large-scale event; instead, the census survey is used to diagnose successes and opportunities, with additional listening and action following. Manager development is sometimes personalized with employee experience or 360 feedback data. Leaders at all levels are comfortable interpreting and acting on feedback, and there is some accountability in place for action. Executives do not make major decisions without seeking employee input or understanding the impact on people's perceptions.



STAGE 4

Continuous Listening and Action

36% **15%** **20%**
2024 2025 2026

The most mature organizations have a robust and flexible listening program integrated deeply into their overall business strategy, enabling workforce transformation at speed and at scale. Stage 4 organizations continue to track workforce issues using planned census events, but are also able to determine the problem they intend to solve and quickly deploy the proper type of listening. Manager and leader development plans include information about leader behavior captured through 360 feedback or behavioral listening. Managers get frequent developmental feedback and have the tools and support to work with their teams to make substantive changes quickly. The employee experience is not the responsibility of HR or the executive team — everyone in the organization is activated to contribute to the conversation.

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"In Stage 4 organizations, the employee experience is not the responsibility of HR or the executive team. Instead, everyone is activated to contribute to the conversation."

What Defines Each Stage?

Organizational Outcomes by Maturity

The positive association between listening maturity and business outcomes remains strong in 2026. The largest gap appears in workforce engagement and retention: **77% of Stage 4 organizations report high levels, compared with just 7% of Stage 1 organizations — an 11× difference.** Adaptability to change (7×), innovation (6×), financial performance (6×), and customer satisfaction (5×) show similarly large spreads.

One notable pattern: there is a dip in financial targets among Stage 2 organizations (9% vs. 11% at Stage 1). This is associated with organizational scale — Stage 2 organizations are disproportionately in Growth and Established phases, where investment in systems temporarily compresses margins. As organizations move into Stage 3, financial outcomes improve sharply, jumping to 32%.

11×

difference in workforce engagement and retention between Stage 1 and Stage 4 organizations

Organizational Outcomes by Maturity Level (2026)

Stage 1 Stage 2 Stage 3 Stage 4

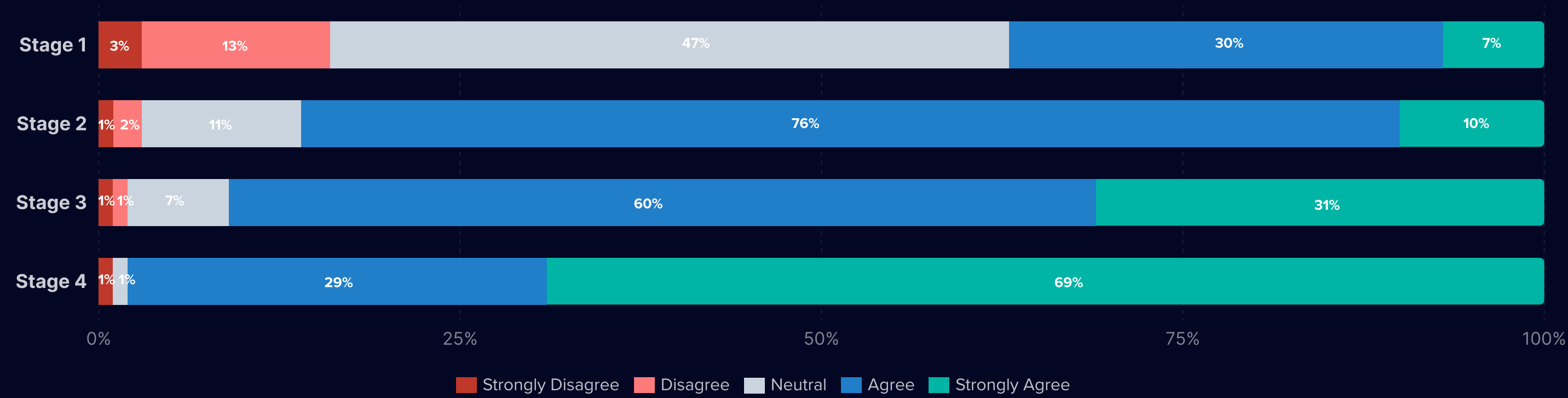
OUTCOME	STAGE 1 → STAGE 4 PROGRESSION			MULTIPLIER
High Workforce Engagement & Retention	Stage 1		7%	11×
	Stage 2		8%	
	Stage 3		36%	
	Stage 4		77%	
Adapts Well to Change	Stage 1		12%	7×
	Stage 2		12%	
	Stage 3		50%	
	Stage 4		81%	
Innovates Effectively	Stage 1		13%	6×
	Stage 2		18%	
	Stage 3		42%	
	Stage 4		82%	
Meets / Exceeds Financial Targets	Stage 1		11%	6×
	Stage 2		9%	
	Stage 3		32%	
	Stage 4		70%	
High Customer Satisfaction & Retention	Stage 1		15%	5×
	Stage 2		17%	
	Stage 3		41%	
	Stage 4		77%	

Can HR Leaders Articulate the Engagement–Performance Connection?

The ability to explain how engagement connects to business performance separates early-stage from mature listening organizations. Among Stage 1 organizations, **47% of HR leaders are neutral** on their ability to make this case, and only 7% strongly agree they can articulate the link. At Stage 4, **69% strongly agree**.

As organizations shift focus toward performance, productivity, and innovation, framing engagement as an enabler of those outcomes becomes essential for budget defense and executive alignment. Stage 1 organizations struggle to make the business case for listening investment precisely when that case is most needed.

Ability to Articulate the Engagement–Business Performance Link, by Maturity



"Nearly half of Stage 1 HR leaders are neutral on whether they can connect engagement to performance. At Stage 4, 69% strongly agree they can."

What Barriers Slow Employee Experience Progress, and How Do They Change by Maturity?

Barriers evolve as listening maturity increases. At Stage 1, the dominant obstacles are cultural: 30% cite culture-outcome alignment and 26% cite leadership buy-in. At Stage 4, leadership buy-in drops to 8%, but the data-to-action gap rises to 31%.

Early-stage organizations need sponsors and cultural clarity before they can act on listening data effectively. Mature organizations have solved for buy-in but face execution complexity: more data, more listening channels, more stakeholders, and greater organizational scale create friction between insight and impact. Change fatigue peaks at Stage 4 (20%), confirming that large-scale, repeated change cycles can produce resistance even when listening is done well. ROI also becomes more salient at higher maturity levels (15% at Stage 4 vs. 10% at Stage 1), as organizations with bigger programs face more scrutiny on returns.

Barriers Slowing EX Progress by Maturity Stage (2026)

BARRIER	STAGE 1	STAGE 2	STAGE 3	STAGE 4	PATTERN
Culture-Outcome Alignment	30%	27%	26%	26%	Dominant at Stage 1
Leadership Buy-In	26%	23%	21%	8%	Drops sharply at Stage 4
Data-to-Action Gap	19%	22%	25%	31%	Rises with maturity
Change Fatigue	16%	19%	15%	20%	Peaks at Stage 4
ROI	10%	10%	13%	15%	More salient at higher stages

For Stage 1–2 Organizations

Focus on sponsorship and cultural alignment: secure executive commitment, define clear outcomes, and connect listening events to specific business problems.

For Stage 3–4 Organizations

Priority shifts to execution capacity: tighten accountability for actions, reduce competing priorities, and build an operating rhythm that turns insight into visible change employees can feel.

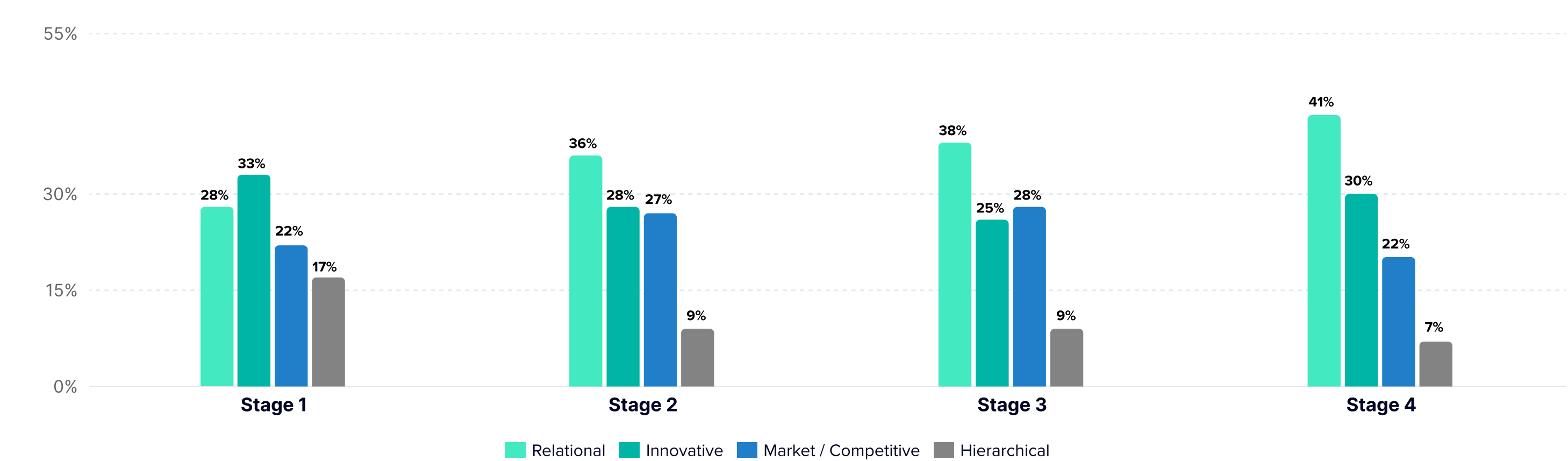
Is There an Association Between Maturity and Organizational Culture?

The 2026 study introduces organizational culture as an analytical lens, using the Competing Values Framework to classify organizations into four types: Relational (flexibility + internal focus), Innovative (flexibility + external focus), Market/Competitive (standardization + external focus), and Hierarchical (standardization + internal focus).

Relational cultures are significantly more likely to achieve high listening maturity. They rise from 28% of Stage 1 organizations to 41% of Stage 4 organizations, a 13-point increase. Hierarchical cultures show the opposite trajectory, declining from 17% at Stage 1 to just 7% at Stage 4.

Innovative cultures maintain relatively high representation across all stages but do not concentrate at Stage 4 the way Relational cultures do. Market/Competitive cultures cluster in Stages 2–3, consistent with their emphasis on output and accountability — sufficient to move beyond episodic listening, but sometimes lacking the flexibility and trust that characterize continuous listening organizations.

Culture Distribution by Maturity Stage



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Relational cultures — those with a bias toward flexibility and an internal focus on employee development — are the most likely to achieve Stage 4 listening maturity.”

How Does Organizational Scale Shape Priorities?

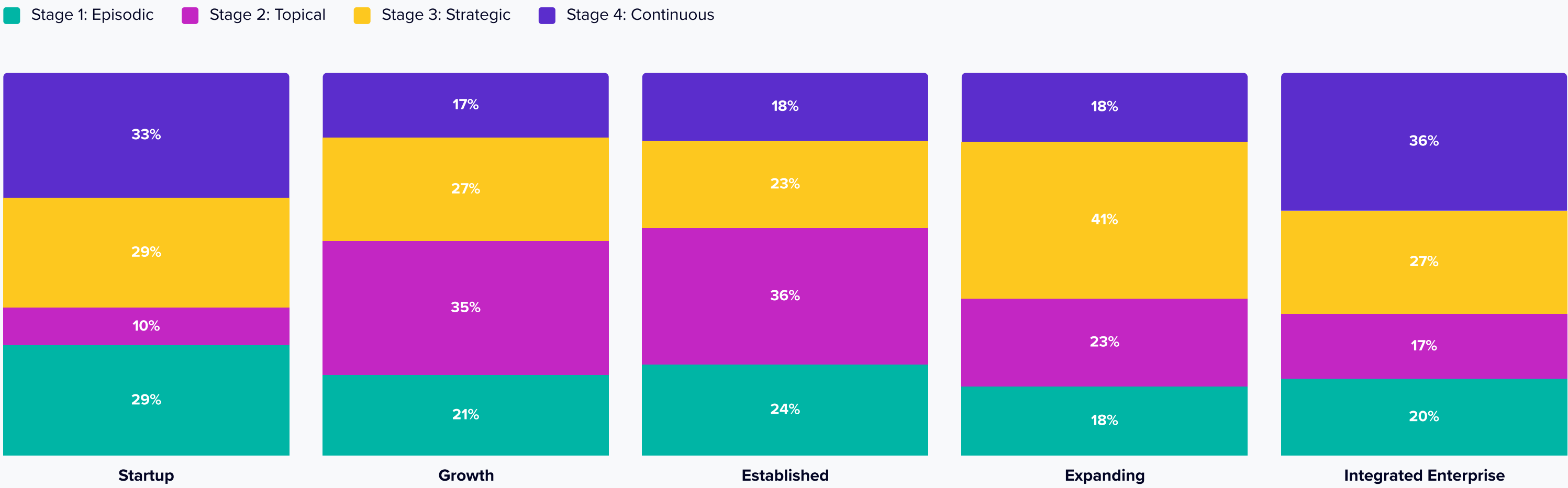
Organizational scale creates real constraints — decision speed, manager span, process depth, and change capacity all shift as organizations grow. Those constraints shape which outcomes leaders prioritize and should shape listening program design.



How Does Scale Relate to Maturity?

Startups show a higher share at Stage 4 (33%), reflecting the speed and agility advantages of small, founder-led organizations that can close the loop between feedback and action quickly. Growth and Established organizations cluster in Stages 2–3, where they have the listening infrastructure but often lack the analytics resources and action governance to move higher. Expanding organizations skew toward Stage 3 (41%), and Integrated Enterprises show the highest concentration at Stage 4 (36%) — the scale at which complexity demands, and often receives, the most integrated approach.

Maturity by Organizational Stage (2026)



33% of Startups are at Stage 4 — speed and agility translate into listening responsiveness

36% of Integrated Enterprises are at Stage 4 — complexity demands the most integrated approach

What Practices Help Organizations Move from Insights to Impact?

The findings across this report converge on three operational constraints that determine whether listening programs deliver value. For each, the data suggest concrete next steps.

CAPACITY Lighten the Lift When HR workload is the top barrier, the solution requires reducing the operational burden of the listening cycle without reducing its coverage. Organizations should standardize action cycles so that planning and follow-through happen in a predictable cadence rather than as special projects. Technology-enabled solutions that surface prioritized, behavioral-science-backed actions directly to managers — without requiring team meetings or separate planning sessions — reduce disruption and increase the probability of follow-through.	BUDGET Build the ROI Narrative The emergence of budget as the #2 barrier means HR leaders must quantify the connection between listening investments and operational metrics. Stage 4 organizations are 6× more likely to meet or exceed financial targets, and organizations with defined business outcomes for their listening programs are nearly 3× as likely to report progress on business and talent priorities. HR leaders should link listening outputs to retention of critical talent segments, productivity metrics, and customer satisfaction scores — and share those links with the executive team in their language.	EXECUTION Set a Visible Operating Rhythm Follow-through remains the universal barrier. Goals are set; actions trail off. The solution is not more planning meetings. Organizations that sustain action involve employees at all levels, equip managers with clear and simple next steps, and make change visible. Transparent communication about what feedback was received and what actions were taken builds the credibility that keeps the listening-action cycle running.
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The Convergence of Listening, Action-Taking, and Learning

The 2026 data reinforce a pattern that prior Perceptyx research has documented across multiple studies: listening maturity produces outcomes only when accompanied by action-taking and personalized development. These three capabilities — listening, action, and learning — operate as a system. Organizations that invest in one but neglect the others see diminishing returns.

The Action Gap

Perceptyx benchmark data show that 71% of employees say their organization shares survey results, and 59% say action plans are created — but only 51% report that actual improvements resulted from feedback.

This 20-point gap between planning and improvement persists across every listening program we study. Across the five years of this study, action planning and follow-through has appeared in the top five barriers in every edition. In 2026, 22% of organizations still cite it. Among Stage 4 organizations, the data-to-action gap (31%) now outranks every other barrier.

71%

of employees say their organization shares survey results, but only 51% report that actual improvements resulted from feedback

What Separates Organizations That Act from Those That Stall

Prior Perceptyx research has examined why some organizations close this gap while others do not. The findings are consistent: organizations without a structured approach to action planning see engagement improve in only 28% of cases. Organizations that equip managers to create and track action plans see engagement gains in 59% of cases. And when employees report experiencing visible behavior change as a result of feedback, **69% of organizations see increased engagement.**

The difference is ongoing behavior change rather than scheduled, check-the-box plan creation. Plans that sit in dashboards produce the same outcomes as no plans at all. Organizations that drive real improvement focus managers on one priority area, identify two specific actions, and schedule follow-up conversations to sustain momentum. Research in behavioral science — including work grounded in Nobel Prize-winning Nudge Theory — shows that small, timely prompts delivered in the flow of work are more than twice as effective as traditional training in producing lasting behavioral change.

28%

engagement improvement — without structured action planning

59%

engagement gains — with manager action plans & tracking

69%

see increased engagement when employees experience visible behavior change

Connecting Listening to Learning & Development

The 2025 State of Employee Listening study introduced the convergence of listening and L&D as a new research area, and the 2026 data expand on that finding. Among Stage 3 and Stage 4 listening organizations, 77% also report effective coaching and development programs — compared with 40% among Stage 1 and Stage 2 organizations. The most mature listeners are 1.8× as likely to use 360 feedback and 1.8× as likely to use employee experience data to personalize learning.

Effective L&D programs independently predict business outcomes. Organizations with the most effective coaching and development programs are 2.3× as likely to meet or exceed financial targets, 2.3× as likely to achieve high workforce engagement and retention, and 2.2× as likely to adapt well to change. When L&D is powered by listening data — so that development content reflects what employees actually experience rather than what HR assumes they need — those outcomes compound.

In a constrained hiring environment where unemployment has risen to 4.4% and nonfarm payrolls contracted in early 2026, organizations cannot solve productivity and retention challenges by adding headcount. They must develop the people they have. Listening data provides the targeting mechanism; personalized coaching and development provides the delivery vehicle; and action-taking at every level provides the behavioral follow-through that makes development stick.

2.3×

Organizations with effective L&D programs are **2.3×** more likely to meet or exceed financial targets

2.3×

Organizations with effective L&D programs are **2.3×** more likely to achieve high workforce engagement & retention

2.2×

Organizations with effective L&D programs are **2.2×** more likely to adapt well to change

77%

of Stage 3–4 organizations also have effective coaching and development programs
vs. 40% among Stage 1–2 organizations

“

"Organizations cannot solve productivity and retention by adding headcount. They must develop the people they have — and listening data tells them exactly where to focus."

—

CONCLUSION

From Insights to Impact

Listening maturity is fragile. Even organizations that had built robust, multi-channel, strategically aligned programs have pulled back under resource constraints. The measured cost is direct: organizations with lower listening maturity are less likely to achieve their engagement, retention, innovation, and financial goals.

The practices associated with high maturity still produce strong outcomes across industries, organizational sizes, and cultural types — though they gain the most traction in Relational cultures that prioritize flexibility and employee development. Organizations that will outperform in 2026 and beyond are those that protect their listening investment, connect it to the outcomes their executives care about, and equip people at every level to act on what they hear.

In 2026, the data directs organizations operating in a constrained labor market toward a single point of convergence at the intersection of listening, action-taking, and personalized development. With critical industries like healthcare facing a projected shortage of 141,000 physicians by 2038, with overall payroll growth slowing, and with all HR budgets under pressure, the organizations that thrive will use employee voice to target development, activate behavior change at scale, and close the gap between insight and impact.

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"The organizations that thrive will use employee voice to target development, activate behavior change at scale, and close the gap between insight and impact."

—

Study Methodology

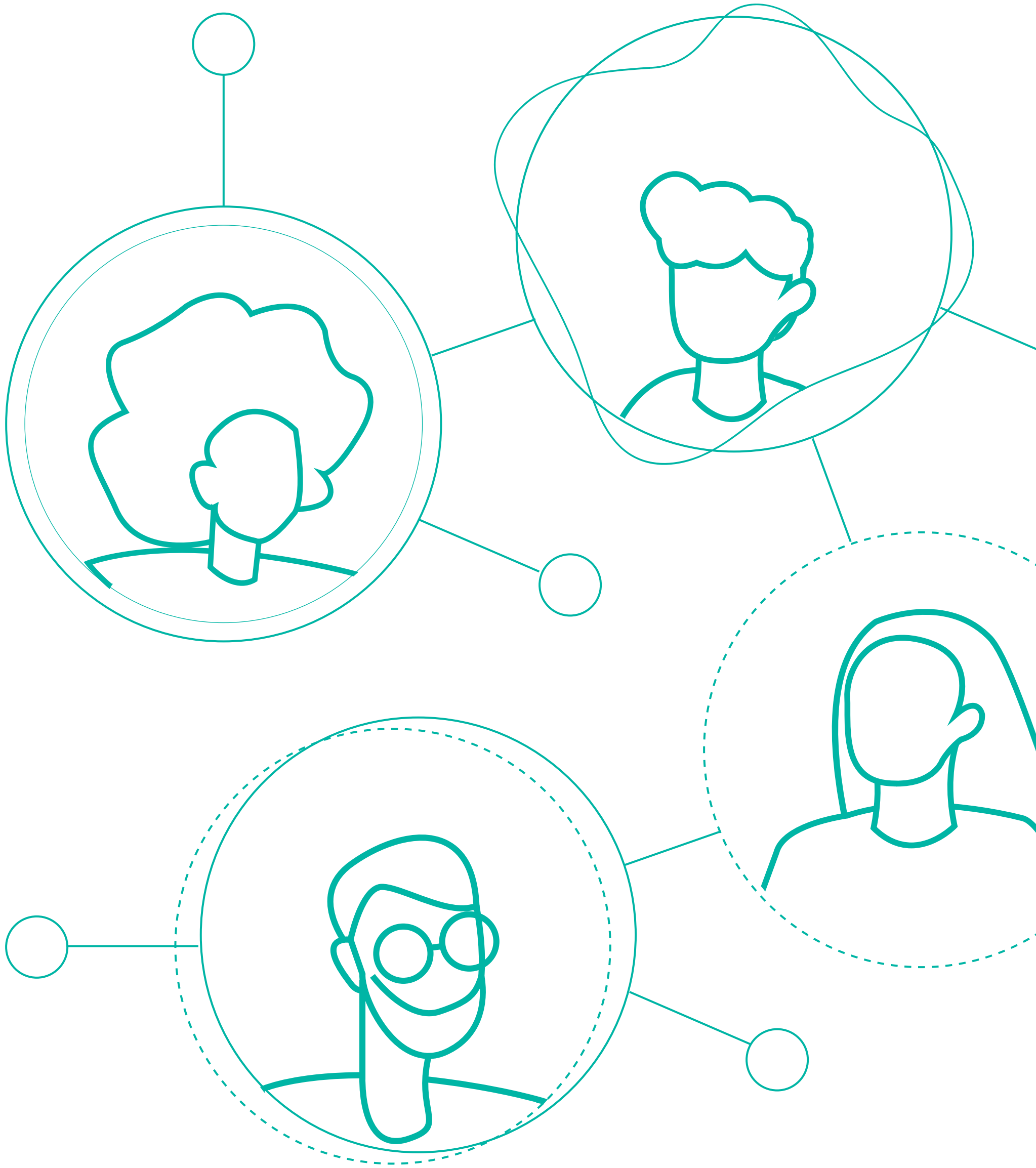
Research for this report utilized panel interviews conducted in early 2026 with more than 750 senior HR decision-makers at organizations with more than 1,000 employees. This sample included leaders in the United States and Europe, with organizations headquartered in seven countries and operating in all regions of the world. Since its inception, the Perceptyx workplace leadership panel has gathered data from more than 4,850 senior leaders representing large, global organizations across all major industries. Comparison data from the 2022, 2023, 2024, and 2025 State of Employee Listening studies are also included in this report.

750+

Senior HR decision-makers at organizations with more than 1,000 employees

4,850+

Senior leaders have contributed to the Perceptyx workplace leadership panel since inception



ABOUT THE AUTHORS



PRINCIPAL AUTHOR
Bradley Wilson, Ph.D.

Global Head of Workforce Insights & Innovation, Perceptyx

Dr. Bradley Wilson serves as Global Head of Workforce Insights & Innovation at Perceptyx, where he leads the strategic vision for how organizations use employee feedback to drive innovation, culture transformation, and performance. A Ph.D.-trained industrial/organizational psychologist, Brad brings over a decade of experience helping Fortune 500 companies with human-centered strategies and data-driven insights. He oversees strategic research and innovation initiatives that explore current practices in behavior change and emerging trends shaping the future of work. Brad's academic background includes a Ph.D. from Grand Canyon University and an M.B.A. from Liberty University.

ADDITIONAL CONTRIBUTORS

Zachary Warman, M.S. Senior Behavioral Scientist	Oliver Bateman, Ph.D. Head of Content and Editorial	Laura Sinkler, M.S. Senior Data Analyst
Daniel Stanczyk Principal Designer	Katherine Kato Senior Web Developer	Scott Diehl VP Creative



About Perceptyx

Perceptyx is the Employee Experience (EX) transformation company, providing enterprise-grade employee listening, analytics, and behavioral science that activates people and delivers business impact. More than 600 global enterprises, including one-third of the Fortune 100, use Perceptyx's multichannel employee listening, AI-powered recommendations, and personalized coaching to close the loop between insights and action.

With an unrivaled technology platform and an in-house team of EX and L&D experts, Perceptyx makes it easy for managers, HR executives, and business leaders to align their key business and talent priorities and drive positive organizational change.

For more information, or to speak with a member of our team, visit www.perceptyx.com

600+ Global enterprise clients

1/3 Of the Fortune 100 use Perceptyx

750+ HR leaders surveyed for this report

4,850+ Leaders in the Perceptyx research panel